Or they could continue supporting Najibullah, who presided over a highly repressive and unstable regime that was making enemies at a faster rate than building allies.

India chose the latter. Sarwari's arrest came eerily close to Najibullah's official visit to New Delhi in mid-1990. It was not hard to fathom that India was keen on keeping Najibullah in good humour even though his authority was being challenged both from inside and out. If the coup of March 1990 had succeeded, Sarwari could have been a potential asset, but with the coup having failed, he was simply an irritant between India and Najibullah. Still, New Delhi had no reason to either love or hate Sarwari. He was a serious political actor in Kabul, had been close to Moscow where many considered him a better presidential candidate than Najibullah, and he was young enough to revive his political career. He had even welcomed Indian ministers to Kabul during the late-1970s and 1980, and advocated closer relations between the two countries. In essence, he represented that breed of Afghan politician who had nothing against India, were politically ruthless, but who fell out of favour with the government of the day in Kabul, and as a result, had lost their voice in, and value for, New Delhi. In April 1992, the eventuality that worried many in India actually occurred. Within nine months of deporting Sarwari, and despite India and the UN's clandestine efforts to protect the embattled president, Najibullah's regime collapsed.

In retrospect, both Sarwari and Najibullah were the first political casualties of India's policy flux vis-à-vis Afghanistan as the Cold War came to an end. Unlike previous decades, including the years when the Soviet Union was in charge of Kabul, India was awakening to the new reality of a broken Afghanistan wrought by civil war. It was a curse, especially in India's relations with Pakistan. From now on, Indian policymakers would face situations when their chosen Afghan friends would make demands to neutralise domestic political rivals (and/or Pakistan's proxies) in Afghanistan. Fulfilling these demands could jeopardise India's political standing in the region (and the world) and endanger the lives of Indians working on the ground in Afghanistan. But if India did not help, then it would lose political ground in a neighbouring country of high strategic value. Effectively, India would be doomed if it decided to go the full way in supporting its chosen Afghan friends, and would be equally doomed if it shied away. This